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Oral history interview with Andrew Chinn, 1991 August 9

Funding for the digital preservation of this interview was provided by a grant from the Save America's Treasures Program of the National Park Service.

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MATTHEW KANGAS: In the University District?

ANDREW CHIN: Yeah, in the University District. And I took him back there. And then a few days later I learned that. . . . Before he left the studio out there, after entertaining us, he put the wire screens, you know, kept the fire's, the sparks come out see. But just somehow what happened, the spark came out, and then it burned the whole building.

MATTHEW KANGAS: Oh, that studio, yes, yes.

ANDREW CHIN: Yeah. Burned the whole building and burned all these works over there, that, you know, part of his work out there is all burned to the ground. Later on there's a booklet come out. It mentioned that he had a bunch of Oriental friends to visit me, the day before. That's us. But didn't mention name but that's us, see.

MATTHEW KANGAS: Well, that was tragic.

ANDREW CHIN: Yeah, it's tragic.

MATTHEW KANGAS: But when you think of your first-hand knowledge of Asian art and then when you think about Graves's strong interest, did he really understand Chinese art?

ANDREW CHIN: Well, that I do not know, but I did know that he use pictures of these Chinese, oh, Chinese metalwork for the early two thousand year ago, you know, _____ _____.

MATTHEW KANGAS: Metalworks?

ANDREW CHIN: Yeah. Not _____ work. It's, you know, like for incense and also for wine holding, the old. . . .

MATTHEW KANGAS: You mean the bronze vessels _____ _____.

ANDREW CHIN: Yeah, yeah, that's right. He went in the library, take a look at a lot of these thing, and make use on his pictures later.

MATTHEW KANGAS: True. But what I'm saying is, what I'm curious is the way that he made his art look like Oriental art. When you first saw that at the time, what did you think? Because after all you are Chinese, he is Western, and you were influenced by perspective, but he was influenced by Japanese—or Chinese—brush painting, but. . . . Was it a curious mixture, or what?

ANDREW CHIN: Well, I couldn't tell much, but for the same token, this other guy, that [he's, his] white writing, you know, to me. . . .

MATTHEW KANGAS: Yeah, [Mark—Ed.] Tobey.

ANDREW CHIN: Yeah, Tobey. To me, it didn't make much sense, because the Chinese writing it talk about power, talk about thin and thick strokes, but with his white lines I cannot see the Chinese influence.

MATTHEW KANGAS: Because there was not enough variation in the stroke?

ANDREW CHIN: That's right. There's no variation in the strokes, and there's no power emphasized, so I couldn't. You say that. I don't understand it, but certainly I don't see the influence.

MATTHEW KANGAS: Well, no, I think you may have a greater insight there and it could be that, you know, since he. . . . That's a whole other topic, Tobey, but I think sometime had converted to the Baha'i faith and it could be that the white writing grows more out of the Islamic Mideast calligraphy.

ANDREW CHIN: Um hmm. But he didn't write Chinese calligraphy, did he?

MATTHEW KANGAS: No, but, I mean, it could be that it's Arabic.

ANDREW CHIN: Oh! Yeah, could be.

MATTHEW KANGAS: _____ Arabic more than Chinese. Although people say, "Oh, it's Asian influence," and, you know, there was an exchange student, Chinese exchange student, in Seattle whom Tobey met. I wonder if you knew him. Teng Kuei?

ANDREW CHIN: Teng Kuei.

MATTHEW KANGAS: 1928. At any rate, the story goes that he learned the Chinese, studied Chinese calligraphy with this exchange student but I, we don't know for sure.